

Ronald J. Tackett, Ph.D.

Founding Head, School of Foundational Studies

Associate Professor of Physics · Kettering University

Professional Statement on the Use of Artificial Intelligence

This statement reflects where I am right now in my thinking about artificial intelligence in my professional work. It is not a final position. I am still working through many of these questions, and I expect this statement to look different in a year or two.

I. CONTEXT

I became Founding Head of the School of Foundational Studies (SoFS) in June 2025, which means I am standing up a new academic unit at a moment when questions about AI in higher education are particularly unsettled. That timing shapes how I think about this. The decisions made now about how the SoFS approaches AI will have some staying power, so I am trying to be deliberate rather than reactive. This statement is part of that effort.

II. HOW I CURRENTLY USE AI

I use AI, primarily Claude (Anthropic's AI assistant), regularly across most areas of my work. On the administrative side, this includes producing documents like budget reports, curriculum memos, faculty communications, and enrollment analyses. Much of the quantitative work is indirect, and deliberately so. Rather than hand institutional data to an AI system, I use Claude to help me write Python programs, usually built on pandas, that parse the standard reports I download from our databases and generate formatted output. Those programs run offline on my own machine, so the data never leaves it. What I am asking AI for in that arrangement is the tooling, not access to the records. In communications, I use AI to refine drafts of memos, letters, and newsletter columns; I bring the substance, and AI helps shape them. For curriculum work, I have used it to help organize reports and recommendations for the SoFS Curriculum Council and the University Curriculum Committee.

I also use AI in building course materials and syllabi, and in the early stages of proposal work, where it helps me outline an argument and pressure-test a draft before it goes anywhere. The throughline in all of this is that AI handles execution on tasks where I have already done the thinking. The judgment, the context, and the decisions remain mine.

Grading deserves its own account, because it is the use students have the most legitimate interest in knowing about. Student names are redacted before any work goes into a tool. I assign every grade myself. What I use AI for is a second pass over work I have already evaluated: checking that I applied the same standard to the twentieth submission as to the first, and that I did not overlook something a student actually did. Consistency across a stack of papers is precisely where human attention degrades, and a second reader helps. The judgment stays mine. What I am checking is whether I exercised it evenly.

What I do not do is take the output on faith. I spot-check rather than verify every line, and I treat whatever goes out under my name as mine regardless of how it was produced. "The tool generated it" is not a defense I am willing to offer, and building a practice that would require me to offer it seems like a bad trade.

III. WHERE I DO NOT USE IT

There are places I keep these tools out entirely, and I think the exclusions say as much about a practice as the uses do.

The first is peer review. I have served on an NSF review panel and I review for several journals, and I do not put proposal or manuscript content into an AI system. NSF prohibits it outright. The reasoning behind that prohibition, that material submitted in confidence should not be fed into a system outside the review process, holds regardless of whether a rule compels it. My own proposals are a different matter entirely; there I use AI to help outline an argument and strengthen a draft, because that work is mine to share.

The second is anything that identifies a person. Some of the administrative work described above touches personnel matters, student records, and student work. Much of the time the question does not arise, because the work is done by code running locally and the records never go anywhere. When I do need to reason through the content of something directly, it is de-identified or aggregated first, so what I am actually discussing is a pattern rather than a person. This is a real constraint on what AI can do for me, and there are analyses I simply do not run as a result. I would rather accept the constraint than leave confidentiality to my judgment in the moment, when the convenient answer and the right one are hard to tell apart.

IV. THE BENEFITS I SEE

The most practical benefit is capacity. My role is broad, and AI allows me to produce work at a level of quality and volume that would otherwise be difficult to sustain. For colleagues, I think the value is similar: less friction on editing and administrative tasks, more time for the work that actually requires human presence. For students, the benefit is real but narrower than it is usually described. A student who has already worked a problem and wants a second explanation at eleven at night is genuinely well served. A student who has not yet attempted the problem is not; the same tool that would have helped an hour later will, at that moment, quietly do the work that was supposed to build the capability. The value is not in the access itself but in where the student is standing when they reach for it.

V. MY CONCERNS

My main concern is that AI makes it easy to skip the productive struggle that builds real competence. In foundational education, especially, the difficulty is not incidental; it is the mechanism (it's the process, not the product, so to speak). Students who reach for AI before they have developed enough judgment to evaluate the output are not being helped; they are being shortchanged. I also worry about institutional policy drifting so far behind actual practice that it becomes meaningless, and about colleagues being left to figure all of this out without much support.

VI. THE PRINCIPLES I TRY TO FOLLOW

A few things guide how I use AI in practice.

- I try to be transparent about when and how I use it. I do not think there is anything to hide, and modeling openness seems important given my role.
- I keep consequential judgments human. Decisions that affect people, including faculty, students, and the direction of the school, are mine to make, not to delegate.
- I think about fitness for purpose. Not every task benefits from AI involvement, and some are better done without it.
- I try to hold myself to the same standard I hold my students to.

I lead a school built on the value of foundational learning. I should not quietly let my own tools erode the habits of mind I am asking students to develop.

VII. AI IN MY COURSES

My AI policy varies by course and assignment, but the underlying message to students is consistent: the difficulty is not the obstacle, it is the point. In foundational education, the struggle to work through a problem, construct an argument, or derive a result is where learning actually happens. A student who offloads that struggle to AI may produce a correct answer, but they have skipped the process that builds the competence the answer is supposed to represent. I try to make that distinction explicit with my students rather than simply restricting or permitting AI use by rule. The policy question I keep coming back to is not whether AI is allowed, but whether its use in a given moment serves the student's development or substitutes for it.

VIII. WHERE I EXPECT THIS TO GO

In administration, I expect to consolidate what I have built and make it accessible to others rather than continue adding to it. In teaching, the more significant shift will come, in my opinion, as AI-assisted problem-solving becomes part of the subject matter in some of my courses rather than something to accommodate around the edges.

At the school level, the work has already moved from designing a framework to using it, and it has moved further outward than I anticipated when I first drafted this statement. In April 2026 I sat down with seven other liberal arts units at technological universities to compare how each of us was structured and what each of us thought we were for. In September I argued to that same group, by then considerably larger, that the question worth asking is not how to accommodate AI but what we are actually educating students for. Making that case to peers clarified my own thinking more than any amount of internal drafting had. It also means I am now committed in public to positions I am still testing, which is uncomfortable in a way I have come to think is useful.

I expect my use of AI to become more deliberate over time, though not necessarily more extensive.

IX. MY COMMITMENTS

I will keep saying plainly how I use these tools, including in rooms where that is not the expected answer. I will keep the consequential judgments (about people, about curriculum, about the direction of the school) on my side of the line, and I will keep the exclusions in Section III intact even when they cost me something. And I will keep checking whether the habits I ask students to build are habits my own practice actually reflects, because a school built on foundational learning cannot be led by someone quietly exempting himself from it.

If this statement reads differently a year from now, that will be because the thinking moved. I would rather revise it in public than leave it standing after I have stopped believing it.

Ronald J. Tackett, Ph.D.

Founding Head, School of Foundational Studies

Associate Professor of Physics

Kettering University · Fall 2026